

using Disk Management—since you’re not permitted to split, delete or format a partition that contains Windows.

If you have used only a portion of the disk for the XP installation, you can use Disk Management to create more partitions (FAT32 or NTFS) on the drive, and assign them drive letters and volume labels. Note also that if you have multiple partitions, you can change their drive letters from here. Also, from the Disk Management window, you can see what partition is the System partition, what partitions are active, and what partitions contain a page file.

So what are Active and System partitions? When your computer is started, there are certain files needed to boot (start) the computer. These boot files reside on the System partition. Once the boot files have been accessed and performed their function, the system files (the files that comprise the XP OS) are accessed to complete the system start. The system files reside on the Boot partition.

So—and the following may seem to make no sense—the boot files reside on the System partition, and the system files reside on the Boot partition. “Active Partition” means the same as “Boot Partition.”

Now for the partitioning process: before you partition your disk(s), you need to know what the different types of partitions are.

1. A primary partition is one from which you can boot operating systems. There is a limitation, however: you can only have four primary partitions.
2. An extended partition is an extension of a primary partition that allows you to have up to 64 logical drives.
3. A logical “partition” is actually called a logical drive; these are not really partitions, but spaces allocated on the disk for addressing data differently. For all practical purposes, though, they look just like drives.